

points to all contenders here. The Siemens C75 and the ME75; and the K300i also have a useful notes feature. On the L6 and the C2500, this notes feature is absent, so if you need to quickly type in a note you will have to compose an SMS and save it as a draft.

The Siemens phones offer a whopping 1,000 phonebook entries each, with up to 20 fields! The L6 gives you just an address and picture per contact, while the C2500 gives six fields (apart from name) and a picture per contact. Both, the L6 and C2500 can hold 500 contacts.

Memory Capacity

With Internet connectivity and a camera being standard, enough memory to store all those pictures and videos is important. None of the phones here have a memory expansion slot. Call it cost cutting or a deliberate attempt to differentiate between these and costlier models—you simply can't excuse a measly 3.5 MB shared memory on a phone (Nokia 6020) that supports GPRS, EDGE, and HSCSD. The LG's C2500 comes as a pleasant surprise with a respectable 64 MB of memory. The phone offers MP3 functionality, and you can listen to MP3s without even inserting the SIM card. The sound quality is not comparable to dedicated MP3 players, but at least you have something to listen to while waiting for a friend or a bus to turn up. The good news continues with FM reception. The Motorola L6, Siemens C75 and ME75 have a 10 MB storage capacity while the SE K300i has slightly more room with 12 MB.

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Motorola SLVR L7-Sleek and easy to use

Ease of use

The menu and navigation on all these phones is simple and straight forward enough, barring a few quirks here and there. On the L6, for example it will take you a while to get the hang of its menu and navigation select key. The C2500, for some reason had no 'centre click' to select, on a keypad that looks like a 5-way keypad. This means as you navigate to your desired menu, you have to shift your fingers to the left in order to press the soft-key and make a selection.

Once you get used to a particular phone, you will invariably find it comfortable to use. Thus, moving from one phone to another takes a while. You'll understand what we are saying if you have shifted from a Nokia to a Philips or to a Siemens. So, if ease of use is an important criterion to you, give yourself some time with a potential purchase before drawing conclusions. If a friend has the model that you want to buy, borrow it for at least half a day and toy with it.

Keypad

For SMS addicts, nothing is more important than keypad comfort and layout. The Motorola SLVR L6 has the most tactile keypad by far. The C2500 has small but well spaced number keys, but the navigation and softkeys seem like they are jammed together. You can quite easily press cancel when you mean to navigate to the right! The Siemens C75 and ME75 could definitely use softer and less noisy keys. The Nokia 6020's rectangular keypad is easy to type on, but the joystick should have been more responsive.

Show Worthy?

After the RAZR, Motorola's fascination with four lettered names continues with the SLVR which is to be pronounced as 'sliver'. The SLVR L6 comes with a bright and clear blue keypad, and its backlight adds functionality as well as style. Clearly, this is a phone meant not just to talk, but to show off. A striking feature of the L6 is its slimness, but at the cost of being longer and broader than most.

The LG C2500 is small and easy to hold—even toss around! A flash of blue from the keypad, while the phone is in standby, seems like an attempt to grab attention. The Siemens C75 and ME75 have a silver metallic colour, rendering a somewhat retro and laidback look. Nothing special about the K300i and the 6020—they're just average-looking phones.

Rs 7,000 to Rs 10,000

Compared to the previous segment, the phones here are more expensive, and you will expect more out of them. Only the Philips Xenium 9@9e and LG S5200 have a megapixel camera, while the others make do with the modest 640 x 480 VGA resolution.

Motorola PEBL

Lifestyle Phones

It certainly looks more chic than a mere pebble. The phone has a unique flip open mechanism. A mild push to the lid makes it snap open in a brisk and sure way. A clear and pleasing blue backlight accentuated by an all-black colour greets you as the flip opens. The screen is a crystal clear 262k colour TFT, lending a sophisticated feel to the PEBL. A nice, easy-to-press keypad pampers you further. Good first impressions. That's what the phone is about.

On to the features though, there is nothing to rave about—5 MB of internal memory and lack of an expansion slot to begin with. You will have to cut short (quite literally) plans of playing videos or music. A 10 or better still, 20 MB capacity would have been nice. Bluetooth and USB (there is no IR) connectivity, a VGA camera and GRPS comprise the basic plumbing of the PEBL. A mini-USB port is used for headphones, charging and USB connectivity. Surprisingly, and unfortunately, the phone cannot be connected as a USB storage drive, but with a 5 MB capacity, it is not a major loss. This and the oversight on memory though, make us wonder if the PEBL was designed in a studio rather than an engineer's desk.

Storing your friend's and that friend's friend (whom you tried to impress with your PEBL) numbers is not difficult thanks to the 1,000 phonebook entries capacity. The velvety feel of the phone had some of us not liking it, while others were neutral on it. Apart from this, the PEBL is one of the snazziest phones we tested. Flaunters will have a gala time with it. A debate rages in our labs on whether the PEBL is meant to be in the hands of a lady, or if it is meant to woo one...

+ Stylish
- Only 5 MB memory
Rating: 3.5/5

